



All: I hope you all have had a relaxing and fulfilling summer...hard to believe another August is here! This issue of the Crusader Alumni Newsletter will feature Spotlight profiles on Andy King, 2006 Crusader Grad...and Kelsey Newman (Schlitz), 2009 Crusader Grad.

First, will be a summary of how the summer went for both the boys and the girls ETG Crusader teams!! We appreciate those that have already contributed back to the Crusaders organization and welcome any further support as we continue to try and provide the best opportunities we can for our athletes!

ETG Boys Update

- The 15U team improved steadily throughout the season, This group had varying success throughout the season but always continued to get better. They did very well in all local events throughout the season and ended the season winning the Classic bracket in Ladera in the last Adidas 3SSB event of the season. They qualified for the top bracket in Rock Hill and played very competitively throughout the season. This was a great group of young guys, and we are excited for their futures.
- The 16U group had a nice mix of players from Nebraska as well as 2 players from the Kansas City area. This group had a lot of success throughout the season, they qualified for the top bracket in Rock Hill and lost 77-74 in the Championship game in Ladera. This group had 8 players and worked around a couple of multi-sport athletes' schedules to play with 7 in 2 Adidas events. London Dada was among the players who continued to improve throughout the season and ended up being recognized by Rivals as a 4 star and #75 player in the class of '27. Additionally, he picked up his first Division 1 offer from the University of Omaha. Tra Moore and Jackson Smith both received offers from the University of Nebraska Kearney during the season. This group also included Lee Robinson (Class of '28) that played up, Lee currently holds a Division 1 offer from Cal State Northridge (CSUN).
- The 17U group that steadily got better and had a diverse mix of players, they had 5 metro Omaha players (Goanar Bamach, Jerrion Williams, Torran Carter-Brown, Emre Gedik and Derek Rollins) as well as 2 players from Missouri (John Fleeman and Mav Hawkins), 1 from Scottsbluff (Nate Kelley) and 1 from Kearney (Jacob Webber). This group qualified for the top bracket in both Adidas bracketed events. In the first round of bracket play in Rock Hill they lost a heart breaker to Indiana Elite 103-100, Indiana Elite would go on to the semifinals as well as win the tournament in Ladera. This group had a great season and was a much-improved group from the 16U team the season prior. Jacob Webber is currently a Top 40 player in the Class of 26 according to On3 and Rivals, he picked up offers from Purdue, Cincinnati, Arizona State and Tennessee in July. They consistently competed in their games, even while playing a schedule that ended up having nearly 10 games against Top 25 ranked teams.



ETG Girls Update

- The 15U team improved steadily throughout the season, Kevin Freeman and Ryan Sears coached the team that included 1 14U player playing up. The team was represented with a mix of players from throughout Nebraska, Iowa and Missouri. This group had varying success throughout the season but always continued to get better. They did very well in all local events throughout the season and ended the season finishing 5th in Rock Hill, SC in the last Adidas 3SSB event of the season. They qualified for the top bracket in Rock Hill and played very competitively throughout the season. This was a great group of young lady's, and we are excited for their futures.
- The 16U group was coached by Ann Prince. This group had a nice mix of players from Nebraska. This group had a lot of success throughout the season, they qualified for the top bracket in Rock Hill and finished 10th in the 3SSB Championships. This group had 10 players and worked around a couple of multi-sport athletes' schedules. Lots of talent on this group with most of the girls receiving D2 offers and/or having interest from D2 and D1 programs.
- Former Crusader Andy Markowski coached the 17U group that steadily got better. This group had a diverse mix of players and had some adversity in the April in May events with injuries and conflicts due to multi-sport athletes. They ended up qualifying for the Classic Bracket of the Adidas tournament. With a healthy full roster this team ended July going 14-0 and winning the Classic Championship in Rock Hill the last weekend. All 8 players have received offers to play basketball at the next level with 5 of them receiving D1 offers and the other 3 getting D2 offers or interest.



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Former Crusader Spotlights

Andy King 2006 Graduate



I had a wonderful experience in the Crusader program. I played my 17s year and of course on the basketball side, it's the reason I was able to get recruited and played at Samford University. But even beyond that, being with and playing with some of the best players in the state from other schools and traveling the country with them were some of my favorite memories. Playing in Kearney, Kansas City, and Las Vegas were some great memories on and off the court.

I was also fortunate to be able to coach in the Crusader program for 10 years and there's no other program I would have wanted to be a part of - getting to work alongside Doug, Jim, Bob, and others helped shape me as a person and a coach. My goal was to always give the kids the same phenomenal experience that I had.

The recruiting process is obviously wildly different than it was in the early 2000s when I went through it as a player or even in the last 15 years as I've helped players through it. What isn't different is players being open and listening to all coaches and schools that are interested. You just never know until you take the time to visit and research. I wasn't sure Samford in Birmingham, AL would be a good fit until I visited. Things like location, play style, and relationship with the head coach are all important factors that should be considered.

Grassroots basketball is night and day different than when I played. The positives are there are so many more opportunities for kids to be on a team and play than there ever were during my time. For me, there were 2 teams: Bison in Lincoln and Crusaders in Omaha. Another positive is



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teams in Nebraska are able to play in some high level leagues/events. There definitely are some negatives as well in terms of competition can be watered down because of the number of teams, as well as a lot of events are you play 4 games and done. Most lack the “tournament” aspect which rewards winning so I don’t always love that the level of competing game to game sometimes isn’t there. Obviously I didn’t talk about NIL which has its own share of positives and negatives.

Currently I am the Head Coach at Elkhorn North HS. We are starting our 6th year as a school, so it’s been quite the journey starting a program from scratch. The improvement has been there each year and we were excited to make our first state tournament last season and make it to the semifinals. I said from day 1 I didn’t want to take any shortcuts in building our program and our players and coaches have worked their tails off for 5 years to get us to where we’re at and our goal is to keep it at a high level consistently.

Off the court, I chase 3 kids around- Milo (6), Charlie (4) and Elaina (1.5). They are getting busier with school and activities so my wife Hilary and I are enjoying that phase a lot. (My wife and I met at Samford University so that’s another reason I will forever be grateful for the Crusader program in giving me opportunities to get there!)



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Kelsey Schiltz 2009 Graduate



1. Can you take a moment and describe your experience while playing with the Crusaders? Any significant moments or memories stand out?

Some of my favorite memories of high school was playing for the Crusaders and getting to travel and play the sport I love. I developed as a player due to the coaching staff's dedication and expertise. A significant moment for me was getting to play on Duke's court and all the various college campuses we were able to see. I truly believe playing for the Crusaders was what enabled me to play college ball.

2. What advice or insight could you give to student athletes and/or coaches regarding the recruiting process?

I'm sure it's changed a lot since I was going through the recruiting process, but I would tell student athletes to not pay attention to all the "noise" or pressure that comes with recruiting. I know everyone wants to be recruited by the best or most prestigious schools, but it's more important to find a program that fits you as a player and a school that fits you as a student. Not every school will do that, even if they are the "best."

3. A little about your life now and any ways athletics may have helped in life preparation.

I'm blessed now to work with athletes playing in all levels as a mental health therapist. I work with many different individuals, but I especially like working with athletes whether it's on performance or strengthening their mental health. Being a former collegiate player, it gives me a unique perspective to better help my clients. I also have young children who are beginning athletics. I see the pressure these kids have from parents at such a young age. I think playing at the college level has given me a different experience that is helping me as a parent as well. I want my kids to enjoy the sport they are playing and develop as a teammate and human being.



Ways you can help support ETG players today

Your generous donation will make this opportunity available for more young players to develop their game on the court, and develop as a young adult off the court. We currently have a need for \$15,000.00 in order to meet the needs of tournament fees, uniform costs and travel reservations. Please consider supporting this noteworthy organization.

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Thank you for your support!



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